Khrushchev's actions. He eventually decided to meet Mikoyan at the airport, but only after learning that in New York the Soviet representative had gone on record supporting the five points. Castro and Mikoyan had a brief conversation that evening, and while Castro tried to be friendly, Mikoyan, as he later reported to Moscow, "could feel his acute dissatisfaction with our policy." Negotiations began on the following morning, November 3, at Castro's residence in Havana. Castro struck a friendly note at the outset, quoting Khrushchev, who apparently had said that "there is a Cuban in the CC CPSU, and that Cuban is A. I. Mikoyan." But after listening to Mikoyan's assurances that he had come to Cuba "to discuss in the most frank way all the unclear questions with the Cuban comrades," Castro vented all the frustration with Soviet actions that he had accumulated during the previous week.[8]

"Reports on 28 October that N. S. Khrushchev had given orders to dismantle missile launchers, that such instructions had been given to Soviet officers, and that there was not a word in the message about the consent of the Cuban government, that report shocked people," Castro told Mikoyan. "Cubans were consumed by a sense of disappointment, confusion and bitterness. In walking along the street, driving to armed units, I observed that people did not understand that decision." It was a long list of grievances in which Castro also mentioned the Platt Amendment, the American legal act that had deprived Cuba of its sovereignty back in 1901. It was assumed that the Soviets were now trying to do the same.[9]

Mikoyan tried to defend the Soviet position but was cut short by tragic news from Moscow: his wife of forty-one years had died. The negotiations were interrupted. Everyone left the room in complete silence. Mikoyan headed back to his residence to absorb the news. Khrushchev offered his ally condolences and the option of returning to Moscow, but Mikoyan decided to stay. "I can't cut short such important business," he told his son, Sergo, who was accompanying him on the trip. He asked Sergo to return to Moscow alone to bury his mother. His only request was to be informed of the date and time of the funeral.

Ashkhen Mikoyan was buried at the Novodevichy Cemetery in Moscow on November 5, and Mikoyan would see the filmed funeral after returning home. Khrushchev, who had sent him to Cuba and promised to attend the